



Information control, role perceptions, and work outcomes of boundary-spanning frontline managers

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ABSTRACT

Previous research demonstrates the destructive consequences of role stress for the work outcomes of employees occupying boundary-spanning positions. Most studies examine the behavior and performance of industrial salespeople. In contrast, limited evidence exists regarding the antecedents and consequences of role stress in service organizations. This article helps fill this notable gap by investigating the correlates of role ambiguity in the context of frontline managers in banking institutions. The article offers a conceptual model and an empirical test using data gathered from 316 bank branch managers. The study findings reveal that information control is an effective mechanism for reducing role ambiguity. The results also indicate that role ambiguity negatively affects job performance and job satisfaction, intrinsic motivation positively relates to job satisfaction, and bank managers' job performance enhances branch effectiveness. The article concludes with a discussion of study implications and suggestions for future research in the field.

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1. Introduction

The critical role of boundary spanners in influencing organizational effectiveness encourages significant research attention in the marketing literature. Researchers show interest in the realization that boundary-spanning positions are susceptible to role stress (Singh et al., 1996). Role stress has detrimental effects on employees' motivation and morale and results in poor outcomes in terms of job satisfaction, job performance, organizational commitment, and turnover rates (Babin and Boles, 1998; Brown and Peterson, 1993; Churchill et al., 1985).

Boundary spanners are commonly the main revenue generators for their firms and the only employees who come in direct contact with the paying customer. Therefore, role stress presents a major obstacle to the achievement of performance objectives. Organizations can benefit greatly by adopting appropriate management practices

that reduce feelings of role stress, especially among customer-contact employees.

This study develops a broad conceptual framework that examines interrelationships among information control, role ambiguity, intrinsic motivation, job outcomes, and organizational effectiveness and offers an empirical test for a structural model using data collected from bank branch managers. Branch managers represent a typical example of a boundary spanner. On the one hand, they constantly battle to achieve the financial and operational performance objectives of their branch, set by upper management. On the other hand, they face constant pressure from bank customers who demand lower interest rates and charges for their credit facilities or higher returns for their deposits and other investments. These managers' success in satisfying the diverse and often conflicting demands of top management, customers, and other stakeholders determines the long-term prosperity of the organization.

The purpose of this study is to extend the existing literature through three specific contributions. First, the study emphasizes the important role of area managers in fulfilling the information needs of branch managers and reducing their level of job- and supervisor-related role ambiguity. Second, the study answers research calls for integrating intrinsic motivation into the job satisfaction model (Brown and Peterson, 1993). Third, the study provides an empirical test for a comprehensive model of the antecedents of frontline managers' job satisfaction and performance in the neglected context of financial service providers.

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